

Spain Family Trip — Barcelona → Madrid

Dates: Wednesday, July 8 → Tuesday, July 14, 2026 (7 days / 6 nights)

Travelers: 4 — Mom & Dad (74), you & your brother (29)

Route: Land Barcelona 9:00 AM Jul 8 → 3 nights Barcelona → AVE train Sat Jul 11 → 3 nights Madrid → fly to NY/NJ Tue Jul 14

Planning notes for a multigenerational trip: central hotels chosen for shortest distances to your actual wishlist, gentle pacing for your parents, timed morning tickets to beat the July heat (highs ~30–36°C / 86–97°F), taxis over long walks, and afternoon rest gaps before the late Spanish dinners.

BOOK TODAY — the trip starts in 3 days

These sell out or get expensive fastest. Book in this order, today:

Priori	What	Slot to book	Price (pp)	Where
1	**Sagrada Família** — Thu Jul 9	**9:00 AM** entry (Quiet Hour)	€26 adult / €21 senior; towers +€10 (sons only)	sagradafamilia.org/en/tickets-individuals
2	**Train BCN→Madrid** — Sat Jul 11	**AVE 03080, 8:25 AM** (nonstop)	~€60–110 Standard, ~€90–140 Confort/Premium	renfe.com
3	**Hotels** (both cities)	Jul 8–11 BCN / Jul 11–14 MAD	—	direct or your booking site
4	**Spotify Camp Nou Experience** — Fri Jul 10	**9:30 AM** guided session (English)	from €69	fcbarcelona.com/en/tickets/camp-nou-experience
5	**Bernabéu Tour** — Mon Jul 13	**9:00 AM** opening (or €44 Flexible-time)	€37 online	realmadrid.com/en-US/tour-bernabeu
6	**Royal Palace** — Sun Jul 12	~10:00 AM timed entry	see site	entradas.patrimoniacionales.es
7	**Tuk-tuk tour Madrid** — Sat Jul 11	~6:30 PM, private, 1.5–2 hr	varies	book a rated operator online in advance

- Sagrada tickets are **nominative — names must match photo ID**, and July 2026 is centenary-year peak season: morning slots genuinely can sell out days ahead. If the 9:00–10:00 window for Jul 9 is gone, take anything before 11:00, or check Tigtets (authorized reseller with separate allotments), or book the guided-tour ticket (sells out slowest). ⚠️ *A teachers'-strike protest was intermittently restricting basilica access as of July 5 — re-check sagradafamilia.org the morning of your visit.*

- Restaurants: **Botín, Casa Lucio, 7 Portes** — call/book online today too. The ultra-fine-dining rooms (Disfrutar, DiverXO) are realistically gone at 3 days' notice, but cancellations happen — try their sites; **StreetXO** takes walk-ins.

At a Glance

Day	Date	Base	Highlights
1	Wed Jul 8	Barcelona	Land 9:00 AM, settle in, Gothic Quarter + beach sunset

2	Thu Jul 9	Barcelona	**Sagrada Família 9:00 AM (reserved)** , beach/pool afternoon
3	Fri Jul 10	Barcelona	**Camp Nou tour 9:30 AM** , beach afternoon, Park Güell evening option
4	Sat Jul 11	→ Madrid	**AVE 8:25→11:27** , lunch at Sol, evening tuk-tuk tour + Plaza Mayor
5	Sun Jul 12	Madrid	Royal Palace, **Mercado de San Miguel** , Sol, Zara + Bershka, La Latina
6	Mon Jul 13	Madrid	**Bernabéu tour 9:00 AM** , Retiro/Prado, San Ginés churros finale
7	Tue Jul 14	→ NY/NJ	Midday nonstop from Madrid-Barajas

Where to Stay — chosen by distance to YOUR list

Barcelona (3 nights: Jul 8-11)

Your Barcelona list = Sagrada Família, Camp Nou, beach, old town, and the train station. I mapped both candidate hotels against every stop:

Destination	Majestic Hotel & Spa (Pg. de Gràcia)	Hotel Arts (beachfront)
Sagrada Família	**8-10 min taxi / 23 min flat walk**	10-15 min taxi
Gothic Quarter	**~24 min flat walk / 8 min taxi**	8-12 min taxi
Barceloneta beach	10-15 min taxi	**on the sand (0 min)**
Park Güell	**11-15 min taxi**	15-25 min taxi
Camp Nou	**10-15 min taxi**	16-25 min taxi
Sants station (train day)	**7-12 min taxi / 12 min metro L3**	12-20 min taxi

Top pick — Majestic Hotel & Spa (5★, Passeig de Gràcia 68). Total distance to your non-beach stops is roughly **half** of Hotel Arts' (≈ 16 km vs ≈ 29 km of taxi legs), it has a rooftop pool with Sagrada Família views for the afternoon heat breaks, and Casa Batlló/La Pedrera are on its doorstep. The beach becomes one short taxi ride on beach afternoons.

Beach-first alternative — Hotel Arts Barcelona (5★, Port Olímpic). If waking up on the sand matters more than shorter sightseeing hops, this stays the pick: beach at the door, beachfront pool, spa — you'll just taxi 10-25 min to everything else.

(W Barcelona and Sofitel/Pullman Skipper remain solid beachfront backups.)

Madrid (3 nights: Jul 11-14)

Top pick — Four Seasons Hotel Madrid (5★, Calle de Sevilla 3). The distance check confirmed it's near-perfect for your list — six of your stops are a flat walk under 13 minutes:

Destination	From the Four Seasons
Puerta del Sol	**5 min walk**
Chocolatería San Ginés	**8-9 min walk**
Bershka (Gran Vía 25)	**8 min walk**
Zara flagship (Gran Vía 34)	**10 min walk**
Plaza Mayor	**9-11 min walk**
Mercado de San Miguel	**12-13 min walk**

Royal Palace	16–18 min walk or 7–10 min taxi
Santiago Bernabéu	10–18 min taxi (~€10–15 for all 4)
Atocha station	6–10 min taxi (~€7–9)

(Alternatives if it's sold out at 3 days' notice: Thompson Madrid or NH Collection Suecia — both keep everything within the same walkable square kilometer.)

Booking tip for both cities: two connecting/adjacent rooms near the lift, and a step-free bathroom for your parents.

Train — Barcelona → Madrid, Saturday July 11 (verified timetable)

Important 2026 reality check: Adif track works add ~25–30 min to *every* train on this line until ~December 2026 — so trips take **3 h+**, **not the advertised 2 h 30**, frequencies are reduced, and fares are high. Verified departures from Renfe's official data for **Saturday, July 11, 2026** (all arrive **Madrid-Puerta de Atocha**):

Train	Departs Sants	Arrives Atocha	Duration	Stops
Renfe AVE 03062	5:50	9:40	3h50	5
Renfe AVE 03302	6:35	9:52	3h17	1
Ouigo (budget)	7:35	11:05	3h30	1
Renfe AVE 03082	8:00	11:44	3h44	4
Renfe AVE 03080	**8:25**	**11:27**	**3h02**	**nonstop**
Renfe AVE 03092	9:00	12:24	3h24	2
Renfe AVE 03304	9:55	13:44	3h49	5

Book the 8:25 AVE 03080 — the only nonstop and the fastest morning train, at a civilized hour for your parents, landing you in Madrid at 11:27 with the whole afternoon and evening ahead. If you want to arrive even earlier, the **6:35 (arr. 9:52) is the early-bird option**. In Elige Confort or Premium **you get wide 2+1** seats, at-seat meal service, and Renfe's free **Atendo** assistance for your parents (request it when booking — they'll help with luggage and boarding at both stations).

Notes: iryo's morning times couldn't be verified (its old 8:45 no longer runs — check iryo.eu directly); Ouigo is cheapest but charges for luggage beyond one cabin bag + one carry-on each. Availability is live-only — book on renfe.com today.

✈ Flight home — Madrid → NY/NJ, Tuesday July 14 (nonstop options)

Flight	Departs MAD	Arrives	Airport	Barajas terminal
United UA50	10:50	13:15	Newark (EWR)	T1
American AA95	10:25	12:30	JFK	T4
Iberia IB211	~12:30	14:55	JFK	T4 (boards T4S)

Delta DL127	12:45	~15:00	JFK	T1
Iberia IB325	16:20	~18:00	JFK	T4 — lands into evening rush

If you haven't booked yet, the **midday Iberia IB211 or Delta DL127** fit your parents best: taxi from the hotel **~8:15-8:30 AM** (fixed **€33 flat fare** to the airport, ~30-45 min), airport by 9:00 (Iberia recommends up to 4 h for US-bound security), and a mid-afternoon landing in New York. Iberia/American board from the **T4S satellite** — budget an extra 30-45 min for the airside train + passport control. *Air Europa's Tuesday service couldn't be confirmed — avoid unless verified.* If your flight is already booked, just apply the same timeline: **leave the hotel** ~4 hours before departure.

Day-by-Day

Day 1 — Wed Jul 8 · Land in Barcelona (9:00 AM)

- **9:00 AM:** land at BCN; taxi to the hotel (~25-35 min, ~€35-40). Rooms likely won't be ready — request early check-in when booking; otherwise leave bags and have a slow coffee/brunch nearby.
- **Afternoon:** nap/pool — everyone will be jet-lagged; protect this rest window.
- **Evening:** gentle **Gothic Quarter + La Rambla** stroll while it cools, then an early tapas dinner. If energy allows, finish with a **sunset drink at a beach chiringuito on Barceloneta**. **Early night — tomorrow has a 9:00 reservation.**

Day 2 — Thu Jul 9 · Sagrada Família (reserved) + Beach

- **8:40 AM:** arrive at the basilica for security (15 min early). **9:00 AM entry** — the "Quiet Hour" slot: **thinnest crowds of the day, morning sun through the blue Nativity-façade glass**, and cool air. Parents use step-free **Entrance B (Carrer de la Marina)** — **lifts throughout, free loaner wheelchairs if wanted.**
- **Towers:** you and your brother can add tower access (+€10) — but Mom & Dad should skip it: the descent is 300-500 narrow spiral stairs on foot, no lift down.
- **Late morning:** stroll/taxi back via **Passeig de Gràcia** — Casa Batlló & La Pedrera façades (steps from the Majestic).
- **Afternoon: beach + pool** heat break — swim at Barceloneta or laze at the rooftop.
- **Evening:** dinner in the Eixample or El Born; optional **sunset harbor cruise** from Port Vell (zero walking, great for the parents).

Day 3 — Fri Jul 10 · FC Barcelona's Camp Nou + Beach

- **9:15 AM:** taxi to **Spotify Camp Nou, Access 15 (C/ Arístides Maillol)** — arrive 15 min before the **9:30 guided Experience session** (latecomers get downgraded to museum-only). ~2 h: museum + trophy gallery + Messi Zone, immersive 360° room, panoramic view of the rebuilt bowl, and guided access into the first-tier stands. Note for Mom & Dad: everything is step-free with lifts **up to**

the panoramic viewpoint; **the final descent into the stands is stairs-only — they** can wait at the viewpoint while you two go down. (Renovation continues: no dressing rooms/pitch walk on the standard route yet.)

- **Lunch + afternoon:** back east for a **final beach afternoon** — Barceloneta or the quieter Nova Icària stretch.
- **Early evening (optional): Park Güell** (taxi to the upper entrance, skip the climb) or the **Montjuïc cable car** for golden-hour views.
- **Night:** seafood/paella farewell dinner (7 Portes or Can Majó). Pack for the train.

Day 4 — Sat Jul 11 · AVE to Madrid + Old-Madrid Evening

- **7:40 AM:** taxi to **Barcelona-Sants** (10–15 min; Atendo assistance meets you if requested).
- **8:25 AM: AVE 03080 nonstop → Madrid-Atocha 11:27.**
- **11:45 AM:** taxi to the Four Seasons (6–10 min); drop bags, lunch near **Puerta del Sol (5-min walk — you're staying on top of it).**
- **Afternoon:** siesta — travel day + tonight is busy.
- **~6:30 PM: Tuk-tuk tour** (pre-booked, private, 1.5–2 h): yes, the touts by Plaza Mayor seem scammy — that's why you book a rated operator ahead — but the format is genuinely perfect here: a fun, zero-walking sweep of the Royal Palace exterior, cathedral, Plaza de Oriente, Gran Vía, and old town in the golden hour.
- **Evening:** dinner under the arcades of **Plaza Mayor.**

Day 5 — Sun Jul 12 · Royal Palace, San Miguel & Shopping

- **10:00 AM: Royal Palace** (timed tickets; lifts available) + **Plaza de Oriente.**
- **~12:30 PM:** flat 10-min walk to **Mercado de San Miguel** — your must-do. Graze long and slow: jamón, croquetas, oysters, vermouth. Arriving before ~1 PM beats the worst crush.
- **Afternoon:** siesta.
- **~6:00 PM: Puerta del Sol** (Km 0 plaque, the bear-and-strawberry-tree statue), then **Bershka (Gran Vía 25)** and the **Zara flagship (Gran Vía 34)** — 8–10 min walks from the hotel. Fold in the **Spanish McDonald's** stop here for the menu comparison the four of you can argue about at dinner.
- **Evening:** Sunday is **La Latina's** big tapas night (Cava Baja) — or Casa Lucio if you snagged a table.

Day 6 — Mon Jul 13 · Real Madrid's Bernabéu + Sweet Finale

- **8:45 AM:** taxi up the Castellana (~15 min, one cab fits all four, ~€10–15).
- **9:00 AM Bernabéu tour at opening** — museum with all 15 European Cups, the renovated bowl with its wraparound 360° screen, changing rooms and dugout. ~2 h. Heads-up: the route includes **numerous stretches of stairs** — if either parent would struggle, the €44 Flexible ticket plus the club's lift-served partial route (contact them ahead) is the safer setup.
- **Lunch + siesta,** then a gentle option: **Retiro Park** (flat, shady, rowboats)

or the **Prado** (benches throughout).

- **Evening:** farewell dinner — **Sobrino de Botín** (world's oldest restaurant, 1725; book now) — then **Chocolatería San Ginés** for the churros-and-thick-chocolate finale, 8 min from the hotel. Pack tonight.

Day 7 — Tue Jul 14 · Fly home to NY/NJ

- ~**8:15 AM:** taxi to Barajas (€33 flat fare, 30–45 min) for a midday nonstop — airport ~4 h ahead per Iberia's US-bound guidance (T4S flyers: extra 30–45 min).
- Land New York mid-afternoon. ¡Buen viaje!

Your Wishlist — all covered

- ☑ **Mercado de San Miguel** — Day 5, long grazing lunch
- ☑ **Tuk-tuk tour** (reputable, pre-booked) — Day 4 evening
- ☑ **Royal Palace** — Day 5 · **Plaza Mayor** — Day 4 evening · **Puerta del Sol** — Days 4–6
- ☑ **Sagrada Família basilica** — reserved **9:00 AM slot, Thu Jul 9**
- ☑ **Camp Nou (FC Barcelona)** — Day 3, 9:30 AM Experience
- ☑ **Santiago Bernabéu (Real Madrid)** — Day 6, 9:00 AM tour
- ☑ **Beach time** — Days 1, 2 & 3
- ☑ **Zara flagship + Bershka** — Day 5 (8–10 min walk from hotel)
- ☑ **Spanish McDonald's** — Day 5 · **San Ginés** — Day 6 finale

Top-Tier Restaurant Picks

With 3 days to go: **book the classics today by phone/web**; treat the 3-star rooms as lottery tickets (check for cancellations). First sitting ~8 PM suits your parents best.

Barcelona

- **Splurge: Disfrutar** (3★ Michelin, ranked world's #1 — cancellations only at this notice), **Lasarte** (3★), or the warmer **Cinc Sentits** (1★).
- **Iconic & family-friendly: 7 Portes** (paella institution, est. 1836), **Els Quatre Gats** (Picasso's haunt), **Can Majó** (beachside paella).
- **Tapas:** Cal Pep, El Xampanyet, Quimet & Quimet — go at opening for seats.

Madrid

- **Splurge: DiverXO** (3★, Spain's hardest table — cancellation-watch only), **DSTAgE** (2★), or walk-in-friendly **StreetXO**.
- **Iconic & family-friendly: Sobrino de Botín** (oldest restaurant on Earth, 1725 — wood-oven suckling pig, steps from Plaza Mayor), **Casa Lucio** (huevos rotos), **Taberna La Bola** (cocido madrileño).
- **Tapas:** San Miguel market grazing + Cava Baja crawl in La Latina (Sunday!).

Comfort & Pacing (traveling with parents at 74)

- **Heat plan:** all big sights are booked at 9:00–9:30 AM starts; afternoons are pool/siesta; evenings are for squares, shopping, and dinners.

- **Taxis liberally:** every leg above is one cheap cab; a standard taxi seats all 4.
- **Renfe Atendo:** free assistance at both stations — request with the ticket.
- **Stairs watch:** Sagrada towers (skip for parents), Camp Nou stands descent (viewpoint wait), Bernabéu route (contact club if concerned). Everything else is step-free or lift-served.
- **Dining:** first sitting ~8 PM, or big lunch + light tapas night.
- **Pharmacies** (green cross) everywhere; carry meds in original packaging + a list of generic names; confirm travel insurance covers all four.

Sources

- Renfe official GTFS timetable feed (service date 2026-07-11) — [renfe.com](https://www.renfe.com) — <https://www.renfe.com> · Ouigo timetables — <https://www.ouigo.com/es/horarios-trenes-ouigo> · [Seat61 Barcelona-Madrid](https://www.seat61.com/trains-and-routes/barcelona-to-madrid-by-train.htm) — <https://www.seat61.com/trains-and-routes/barcelona-to-madrid-by-train.htm>
- Sagrada Família — official tickets — <https://sagradafamilia.org/en/tickets-individuals> · hours & access — <https://sagradafamilia.org/en/schedules-how-to-get>
- FC Barcelona — Camp Nou Experience — <https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/tickets/camp-nou-experience> · [tours-are-back announcement](https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/club/news/4440096/spotify-camp-nou-tours-are-back) — <https://www.fcbarcelona.com/en/club/news/4440096/spotify-camp-nou-tours-are-back>
- Real Madrid — Bernabéu Tour — <https://www.realmadrid.com/en-US/tour-bernabeu/individual>
- Iberia US-bound arrival guidance — <https://www.iberia.com/us/time-limit/> · Madrid airport taxi flat fare — <https://www.madrid-traveller.com/madrid-airport-to-the-city-center/> · MAD-JFK nonstops — <https://www.flightconnections.com/flights-from-mad-to-jfk>
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